

Minbar Panels

From one or two minbars attributed to Sultan Jaqmaq

Burji Mamluk, 848-55 AH / 1444-51 CE

403 - W: 45 cm; H: 14 cm 405 - W: 45 cm; H: 14.5 cm

Inv. no. 403, 405

These two panels are among the sole surviving elements of one or possibly two minbars attributed to Sultan Jaqmaq (r. 1438-53). Both bear identical foundation inscriptions in naskh which read: “Ordered the construction of this blessed minbar, [our lord] the Sultan al-Malik al-Zahir Abu Sa’id Muhammad Jaqmaq, may his victory be glorified.” Among the pair, No. 405 is distinguished by sharper calligraphic outlines and a more assured execution, suggesting either a different hand or a higher level of craftsmanship within the same commission. Their size and content suggest they originally flanked the passage doors (abwab al-roda) on either side of a minbar, although it remains uncertain which of Jaqmaq’s minbars they were part of. The sultan is known to have erected three mosques during his lifetime: one on al-Marasina St. near the mosque of Sayyida Zaynab, another in Darb al-Sa’ada, and a third, no longer extant, in al-Fustat. Today, new minbars survive in the two extant mosques, making these panels a rare remnant of the lost originals. Identical inscriptions also appear on the flanks of the minbar Jaqmaq commissioned for Sultan Barquq’s complex (786-88 AH / 1384-86 CE) on al-Mu’izz Street. Although Jaqmaq was not known for extensive or innovative artistic patronage, such commissions, often in the context of restoration or renewal, appear to have served as a means of asserting personal piety and architectural stewardship rather than visual ambition.